dola Talav. Folks collected their scanty belongings and fled, some to Mumbai, some back to their home states, most to nearby ghettos.

Intelligence inputs set up an omnibus incrimination: "harbouring Bangladeshi aliens and anti-national elements, large-scale prostitution... drug trade, money-laundering, forgery". Four Bangladeshis tied to an "Al Qaeda module" were picked up, the state told the court, arguing that pre-emptive action to protect "public order" and "national security" cannot be "hounded by principles of natural justice".

Two of the men typified the hold-all approach: Lallu Bihari alias Mehmood Pathan and son Fateh. The charges: forging electricity bills and rent agreements (to help procure Aadhaar cards), human trafficking, prostitution and, strikingly, 'encroachment in Chandola Lake'. Lallu, audaciously enough, had built his house and a large parking shed by reclaiming land from the lake!

"It's just a mercenary move driven by real estate magnates eyeing the lakefront," says activist Mujahid Nafees. "They're persecuting poor Muslims for that." The AMC's 2025-26 budget has a Rs 600 crore waterfront development plan with a 4,000-unit PM Awas Yojana scheme. Pahalgam, unwittingly, has unmade and made homes. ■

▶ RAJASTHAN

BAPTISM BY FIRE

As a Bharat Adivasi Party MLA lands in a graft case, the BJP lets loose its full artillery in tribal Banswara

By **Rohit Parihar**





AGIT PROP One of the many BJP protests against BAP's Jai Krishn Patel (inset)

LIKE A KEEN-EYED kingfisher perched near the water in one of the bird sanctuaries of lake-rich Banswara, it was almost as if they were waiting to pounce on a straying fish. Jai Krishn Patel obliged, or so it looks like. The MLA from Bagidora, a young tribal leader of the Bharat Adivasi Party (BAP), was allegedly caught accepting Rs 20 lakh, as part of a putative bribe of Rs 2 crore. Reportedly in exchange for withdrawing, from the assembly, questions on a mining contract and related illegalities, and promising to keep mum on the matter. Patel got the rap, landed in prison. The cash was allegedly recovered, buried in the soil by kinfolk. Soon, the BJP was unleashing a full-spectrum fusillade of protests against the tribal leader all across the district.

It's not tough to discern why. Banswara, with its strong tribal flavours, is the deepest fortress of the BAP—a party that has successfully positioned itself as the primary magnet for Adivasi loyalties, distinguishing them from mainstream Hindu identities. That hurts the BJP's universally saffron-dyed politics. Theoretically, this also challenges the other political behemoth of Rajasthan, the Congress. But, after a wee bit of hesitation, the Grand Old Party had quickly pivoted to lasso the BAP into its INDIA bloc, along with the Left, ahead of the general election.

The rise of the BAP has been quite the striking phenomenon. Its birth dates only to 2023, but it made a splashy debut in the ensuing assembly and Lok Sabha polls, emerging as the state's third-largest party with four MLAs and one MP. That Lok Sabha entrant was founder Rajkumar Roat, and he represents Banswara.

GRAFT AND STATECRAFT

Now the scandal has cast a shadow over its future. Granted 'state party' status only in January, BAP is drawing harsh censure. Speaker Vasudev Devnani noted that Patel had been warned before against withdrawing questions once submitted to the assembly. While 'cash-for-query' briberies are an open secret in Indian politics, this marks the first such arrest in Rajasthan.

The BJP's blitz is strategic. It aims to reclaim influence in the tribal regions of south and southeastern Rajasthan, where it lost ground to the BAP. In